colleagues, he was a near-mystical figure, a font of unalloyed scientific truth. “We all look up to you as the profoundest thinker in science,” wrote the English chemist Frederick Donnan in a letter to Bohr, “the Heaven-sent expounder of the real meaning of these modern advances.… I can and will think of you walking in your beautiful gardens, and stealing some moments of peace whilst the leaves and the flowers and the birds whisper their secrets to you.”

Bohr’s remarkable charisma was enhanced by his immense institutional power. The Danish government created and funded a research institute with the sole purpose of giving Bohr an environment to work in. The Danish Academy of Arts and Sciences chose Bohr to be the resident of the Carlsberg House of Honor, built and funded by the Carlsberg corporation, the great Danish beer-brewing company. The scion of a leading Danish intellectual family, Bohr regularly entertained at his home not only physicists but artists, politicians, and even the Danish royal family. For the young physicists who came to Copenhagen, “Bohr could provide intellectual stimulation and help in advancing careers, spiritual fulfillment and down-to-earth fun, material benefits and psychological counsel,” as the historian of science Mara Beller put it. “He became a father figure who many young scientists were eager to honor and whose authority not many dared to challenge.” Indeed, Bohr’s influence on his students’ lives often went well beyond the professional into the intensely personal: according to Victor Weisskopf, one of Bohr’s most brilliant students, “any physicist working with Bohr was certain to be married after no more than two years.”

Visiting the great sage of Copenhagen was intellectually and emotionally overwhelming, especially for young scientists. “Bohr had invited a number of us out to Carlsberg where, sipping our coffee after dinner, we sat close to him—some literally at his feet, on the floor—so as not to miss a word,” wrote Otto Frisch, another of Bohr’s students. “Here, I felt, was Socrates come to life again, tossing us challenges in his gentle way, lifting each argument onto a higher plane, drawing wisdom out of us which we didn’t know was in us (and which, of course, wasn’t). Our conversations ranged from religion to genetics, from politics to art; and when I cycled home through the streets of Copenhagen, fragrant with lilac or wet with rain, I felt intoxicated with the heady spirit of Platonic dialogue.”